Spilt Milk

By Tim Miller

I was hitchhiking to San Francisco. I had started out from Bakersfield first thing in the California, springtime morning, hitch-hopping with several short rides up Highway 99. My thumb had been out on the on-ramps of San Fernando, on the on-ramps of Delano, on the on-ramps of Fresno and a long wait on the on-ramps of dreary Merced, too.

And now my thumb was out on a postnuclear-looking stretch of Modesto. I walked backward along the freeway on-ramp, smiling in my best "I'm-not-a-serial-killer-and-I-hope-neither-are-you" manner. My thumb was out. My body was young. My heart was pure. I was emotionally completely tucked-up, and I needed a ride pronto.

I was going to San Francisco for a few days. I was nineteen. As late seventies, Southern California, punk-rock kid, I had missed out on the

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hippie/antiwar/cultural revolution by about ten years, but I felt the weight of the previous generation's nostalgia as heavy as a truckload of Woodstock albums on my skinny chest.

But important things seemed to be happening up in San Francisco. There was this new mayor named Moscone, a good guy. Also, this fellow named Harvey Milk had gotten elected a few months before to citywide office. He was gay like me. It was a revolution, a better world trying to be born. El Dorado. The Grail. The perfectible social order. So, I was on my way to check it out and offer my assistance. I had an address of a friend of a friend of a friend-and twelve dollars in my pocket. I was not nearly as smart as I thought I was, but at least I was starting to realize that.

INTRODUCTION

Harvey Bernard Milk was the first openly gay man to be elected to public office in the United States (and only the second open homosexual, after Massachusetts State Assembly member Elaine Noble). Milk's tenure in office was tragically short-lived. On November 27, 1978, after serving

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on the San Francisco Board of Supervisors for only 11 months, Milk and San Francisco Mayor George Moscone were assassinated by Dan White, a disgruntled former Supervisor who had resigned in opposition to the recent passage of Milk's only significant piece of legislation, a landmark gay rights ordinance.

White crawled in through a basement window at City Hall to avoid the metal detectors; he walked into the Mayor's office and shot Moscone at point-blank range; then he reloaded his gun and walked down the corridor to kill Milk.

For young gay men, San Francisco in the 1970's represented a hope of a new freedom, due in large part to the political contribution of Harvey Milk. This autobiographical excerpt from Tim Miller's Spilt Milk paints a picture of the time that was the 70's in San Francisco.

My thumb was out. Three cars whooshed past without slowing down, not even bothering to glance in their rearview mirror.

Maybe this '74 Vega will stop? Whoosh. Nope! Perhaps this '72 Ford Capri? Whoosh. Nope again!

Finally, I heard the crackle of rubber on gravel as a canary yellow Pinto eased its way onto the shoulder. Two hours later I found myself in San Francisco at

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Powell and Market streets, a comer which reminded me of so many *cheap* family vacations to the Bay Area.

I am not that kid with my family anymore. I repeated to myself this mantra as I hoisted my backpack to my shoulders. *I am a self-motivated, young gay man who has escaped from his family. I am on a hero's journey to find immediately a cute boy or the ideal political system. I am a self-motivated, young gay man. . .*

"Hello," the girl said. "We're from the Creative Community Project, a progressive forward-looking communal organization working toward a new world order. Please join us for a delicious free meal on our bus as we travel to our utopian farm. My name is Jennie. What's yours?"

Her offer did *sound* pretty good to me. I had been hitchhiking for sixteen hours and had only twelve dollars in my pocket. The offer from these seemingly friendly folk of a ride on a bus with free food was pretty tempting. Also, wasn't this the kind of thing

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that's supposed to happen your first ten minutes in San Francisco?

I made a decision. "Sure. I'll come with you." I got on the bus with this group of odd, smiling people.

"All aboard for utopia!" the bus driver cackled, pounding the clutch as he forced the beat-up gears to mesh. The doors hissed closed as we drove down Market Street.

On the bus, there was a buffet spread out at the back with some very strange food. The dishes all seemed to be made with broccoli as the main ingredient. In fact, everything was made with wilted broccoli, the kind that you might find tossed in a Dumpster at the back of a supermarket. The million little nubs on the broccoli were all droopy and yellow. There were wilted broccoli muffins. Wilted broccoli sandwiches. Wilted broccoli casserole. Wilted broccoli danish! What did all this wilted broccoli mean?

As the lights of San Francisco faded behind us, I grew skeptical. I found anew mantra: *This is a progressive forward-looking communal organization*

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working toward a new world order! This is a progressive forward. . .

Three hours later the bus creaked and grinded over a dirt road a hundred and fifty miles north of San Francisco to what my hosts referred to as their "utopian farm." Rubbing a bad dream from my eyes, I staggered off the bus and found myself in a new nightmare. I had a flash for a panicked moment of barking dogs and German accents in the floodlight-illuminated parking area. Emergency mantra: *This is not Dachau. This is not Dachau. This is not. . .*

Immediately after breakfast the next morning the elders in charge gathered us in a circle in a meadow. I was then tortured with several hours of indoctrination, calisthenics and camp songs. During one lecture there was this heavyset guy at a blackboard drawing incomprehensible diagrams as he tried to explain to us everything we needed to know: the function of good and bad in the universe. The ultimate evil of Communism. How man and woman could be happy and complete only through the union of heterosexual marriage.

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I finally lost it during one of our many exercise breaks. We were coerced out onto the playing field for a set of volleyball. I had definitely had enough. I broke away from the game and approached the smiling scorekeeper. "Look, time out," I sputtered out my words. "I don't think I'm cut out to be a member of a cult. I have an appointment with someone in the Haight in just two hours, so could you please get me my backpack and sleeping bag and then drive me back to San Francisco?"

There was complete silence on the volleyball court. A skinny member of the staff ran off toward the main building. A siren began to wail in the distance. The dogs were let loose. I pulled away as the Boonville camp staff surrounded me, backing me against a California oak. I imagined they all were hiding something behind their backs. As my breath raced, I saw that the staffers all carried. . . heads of broccoli. I was locked in a battle with the attack of the Broccoli Brain Suckers!

"Back!" I shouted, "I am the Antichrist. I am a Communist. I am GAY!" (What else can I say to scare

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them away?) "Get me my backpack and sleeping bag now, or I'll call the police!"

Well, that did the trick. About one second later the camp bouncers dumped me and my backpack out on the dirt road. I was breathing fast. I looked around. The world was still there. I had managed to escape from the bizarre clutches of the broccoli brain snatchers.

Scared, shaking but breathing, I braced myself for my second day in San Francisco.

I wandered around North Beach, the direct-from-central-casting fog wisping around my ankles. I felt depressed. Disillusioned. What had I expected? What did I want?

I thought going to the beach might restore me. I got on a bus and I went out to Land's End. It was unbearably beautiful there. Climbing over one razor-sharp rock, I suddenly saw a vision: a sinewy, young man with curly, long, brown hair was dipping his foot in the ice-cube-cold sea. He looked directly at me and smiled. I almost fainted. I jumped in the water and strode toward this man through the icy surf.

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"Hey! Isn't the water cold?" he shouted to me.

"I . . . urn . . . oh!" I sounded like an idiot. I looked at this guy through my dangling water-soaked curls. He was so confident, so sure of himself. How did he get like that?

He pulled me out of the surf. "I'm Michael."

"I'm-m-m-m-m Tim."

"Would you like to come to my house tonight?" Michael asked. "I live in a small, socialist gay men's commune in the Mission. We compost and everything. Well, we're having a meal tonight. A few of us are thinking about going to Cuba as part of the Venceremos Brigade to help bring in the sugarcane harvest and defeat the imperialist U.S. embargo. Would you like to join us?"

"I'd love to."

Since we didn't have any paper, Michael neatly printed his phone number on the inside of my arm with the same fluorescent green highlighter. "There," he said as he capped the pen. "Now you won't lose me."

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Weaving my future with Michael, I drifted into a sun-baked sleep. I imagined our dinner that night. *There will be a brood of dynamic, leftist gay men in attendance. We will eat a delicious ovo-vegetarian meal that Michael and I will prepare. I'll commit to going to Cuba with them. "Venceremos! We shall be victorious!" we will all shout. At the right moment Michael will invite me into his bedroom to listen to his album of whale songs.* The tide came in and woke me up.

Two hours later I was walking in downtown San Francisco killing time before my date. Carefully checking the bright green numbers marked on my arm, I called Michael to get directions to his house in the Mission District.

"Hi, Michael. It's me, Tim, the guy you met at Land's End."

"What shall I make for us to eat?" Michael asked. "Do you like broccoli?"

"Sure," I said with a gulp. "I love broccoli."

I hung up resigned to yet another dinner of broccoli. I made a detour on Fulton Street so I could

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see City Hall before I went to Michael's flat. I wanted to check out the building where Harvey Milk was changing the world. Well, at least my world. Finally, I arrived at City Hall and I looked at the vaulted dome high above me. I thought to myself, *Why is this building so huge? Is it because there is a big idea inside? It looks like it could be the Capitol of an empire or something, not just a City Hall.*

I looked at the huge building and I felt a huge joy. There I was, a foolish, young man. I felt the wheels of the state apparatus, for once, grinding begrudgingly in concert with me. There was a guy named Harvey Milk, gay like me, inside City Hall tickling the power that be! I felt so strong. I felt for once that the world was not an enemy, that society *was* perfectible.

My body was in front of City Hall. I could feel my skin, my feelings, my hopes for the future as tangible as the sidewalk under my feet. For once the law and the government would not pull the rug out from under me. I had all these powerful feelings and a date for dinner with Michael, too.

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As I walked away from City Hall, I thought to myself, *Well, I guess I'll have to go back to Whittier pretty soon. I only have three dollars left. Maybe I won't go to New York. I want to come back to San Francisco and make a life in this city someday.* But, for now, I went off to my broccoli.

A few months later, I was working another soul-killing job at a gas station, trying to make ends meet. As I pumped gas into an old man's Buick, I overheard two other people in a pickup truck having this conversation.

"Hey, d'ya hear the news?" this obvious jerk in the truck slurred through his open door. "They got those two guys up in Frisco. Yeah, some ex-cop killed that queer Milk and that mayor of theirs, whashizname, Macaroni?"

I dropped the gas nozzle to my side. I knew it was time to leave California. I was covered in gasoline.

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